

DBT Distress Tolerance Toolkit

Crisis Survival Skills

Use these skills when you are in a crisis situation and need to tolerate distress without making things worse. Practice these skills before you need them.

TIPP Skills — Change Your Body Chemistry Fast

T — Temperature

Hold ice cubes, splash cold water on your face, or take a cold shower. Cold temperature activates the dive reflex and calms your nervous system quickly.

My plan:

I — Intense Exercise

Run, jump, do pushups, or dance vigorously for 10-20 minutes. Intense exercise burns off the adrenaline and cortisol flooding your system.

My plan:

P — Paced Breathing

Breathe in for 4 counts, hold for 4, breathe out for 6-8 counts. Slow exhales activate your parasympathetic nervous system.

My plan:

P — Paired Muscle Relaxation

Tense each muscle group for 5 seconds while breathing in, then release while breathing out and saying "relax" silently.

My plan:

ACCEPTS — Distraction Skills

When you need to take your mind off the crisis temporarily

A — Activities

Do something that requires focus: exercise, clean, cook, play a game, garden, read.

My go-to:

C — Contributing

Help someone else: volunteer, do a kind act, write an encouraging note.

My go-to:

C — Comparisons

Compare to times you coped well, or to those less fortunate (use with compassion).

My go-to:

E — Emotions (opposite)

Watch a funny movie when sad, listen to upbeat music, read inspiring stories.

My go-to:

P — Pushing Away

Mentally put the situation in a box and place it on a shelf. You'll come back to it later.

My go-to:

T — Thoughts

Count to 10, do a puzzle, recite song lyrics, describe objects in the room in detail.

My go-to:

S — Sensations

Hold ice, snap a rubber band, taste something sour, smell peppermint.

My go-to:

IMPROVE the Moment

Making the current moment more bearable

I — Imagery

Imagine a safe, peaceful place. Visualize yourself coping successfully.

My plan:

M — Meaning

Find purpose or meaning in the pain. What can this experience teach you?

My plan:

P — Prayer/Meditation

Connect with your higher power, practice mindfulness, or meditate.

My plan:

R — Relaxation

Progressive muscle relaxation, hot bath, gentle stretching, deep breathing.

My plan:

O — One Thing at a Time

Focus entirely on just this one moment. Don't think ahead or behind.

My plan:

V — Vacation (brief)

Take a 20-minute mental vacation: read, take a walk, sit in nature.

My plan:

E — Encouragement

Talk to yourself like a supportive friend: "I can handle this. This will pass."

My plan:

Pros & Cons of Tolerating Distress

Use this before acting on crisis urges

PROS	CONS

My Personal Crisis Survival Plan

When I notice my distress level is above a 7, I will first try:

If that doesn't work, my backup plan is:

Person I can call for support:

My self-encouragement statement: